

MITJA SEVEREK, 3.A

1. **READING COMPREHENSION:** In the following extract, eleven sentence parts have been removed. Choose from sentence parts A–M the one which fits each gap (1–11). There are TWO extra sentence parts which you do not need to use. Write your answers in the table below. There is an example at the beginning: Gap 0 (N).

The cactus poachers of Phoenix who are ruining the Arizona desert

The rough hands of a smuggler move quickly in the chill night air. He'll sacrifice a few lives if it improves his speed. After all, he needs to get away undetected [0] and the heat of the Arizona desert threatens to burn his skin.

His prize, which can command thousands of dollars on the black market, has been classified as one of the top five most endangered organisms on the planet by The International Union for Conservation of Nature (IUCN). But poachers like him, most commonly from Europe and Asia, will risk hefty fines, deportation and even imprisonment [1]. Their stolen trophies can't even call out in protest – for a cactus has no voice.

According to the IUCN, 31 per cent of cactus species are currently critically threatened with extinction, [2]. At the sprawling Desert Botanical Gardens, just 15 minutes from downtown Phoenix, Arizona, more than 50,000 cactus and succulent plants are housed over 140 acres of the Sonoran desert. Here in the greenhouses, labs, herbarium and public gardens, rare and endangered cacti species are nursed back to health, cultivated, propagated, catalogued, and saved.

"It's big money – there is a huge black market for cacti, [3]," director of research, Kimberlie A McCue, PhD, says as she tours me around the facility along with Steven Blackwell, the conservation collections manager.

The prickly appearance of cacti may lead some people to care less about its plight but this illegal trade is just as morally bankrupt as poaching elephants for their tusks. In fact, Kimberlie explains, "Cacti are protected under the same international treaty as elephants. It's illegal to move these plants [4]."

Law enforcement agencies have to act quickly to keep up with the antics of thieves and are often a few steps behind. As soon as word gets out that a rare species of cactus has been found, [5]. "They'll just disappear, like that," Kimberlie says, snapping her fingers.

Steven is responsible for habitat restoration and species reintroduction; his work aims to reverse some of the damage wreaked by the poachers. He takes rare plants and uses them to propagate other plants, [6]. If species are ravaged in the wild, the genetic diversity is preserved so long as they have these propagules, also called germplasm, stored here in the garden.

"We call this our back stop against extinction," he says.

The Melocactus is housed here, whose appearance ranges from a round ball to a short tower of spiky green spines with crowns in varying colours, and has a white cephalium which looks like spun yarn. One of the scientists here conducted research in the Dominican Republic and witnessed piles of the rare plant dug up and sold on the side of the road for mere pesos. Some local people in rural communities believe the plant to have medicinal benefits.

Whether it's for big money, or due to ignorance or superstition, the cactus has many enemies.

As we leave this area, I take a moment to marvel at the sheer size of a saguaro cactus looming over the entrance between greenhouse bays and the lab, and Steven chuckles at my response. "I love that reaction," he says. "I walk by it all the time, [7]." He smiles wistfully.

Steven describes plants as his passion and says working at the botanical garden, which opened in 1939 and receives over 600,000 visitors per year, is "the best job".

We now move through to the herbarium, meeting Sarah Hunkins, who manages this giant collection of 80,000 samples. This actually only makes it a mid-sized living library compared to a mega complex such as Kew Gardens, [8].

"I absolutely believe that the information contained in a herbarium is every bit as valuable as any library," she says. "The practice of preserving plants this way started 500 years ago, [9]."

That method includes the collection of plants, followed by pressing and drying. Sarah shows me some comparisons between modern samples and older examples. Now plants are mounted on archival paper and more information is included, [10], helping to build a record of where the plants are thriving and where they are being decimated.

As Kimberlie leads me back into the botanical gardens she explains how the park is funded with contributions coming from a range of private donors and federal agencies, [11]. When I ask her if she anticipates any impact on their funding with this new administration, she sighs audibly. "Oh my gosh, that is what we think about every day!"

This is the sort of thing that keeps researchers and scientists up at night.

(Adapted from an article in *The Independent*, 15 September 2017, by Fionna Tapp)

- ~~A~~ creating the garden's seed bank, which he manages
- ~~B~~ and it's more or less still done the same way
- ~~C~~ such as GPS co-ordinates showing the exact site of collection
- ~~D~~ to protect the endangered cacti
- ~~E~~ many of which President Trump has threatened in his proposed budget cuts
- ~~F~~ which has over eight million samples
- ~~G~~ unless you have the proper documents
- ~~H~~ to catch and sell the rarest specimens
- ~~I~~ the area is raided
- ~~J~~ but the effects could be devastating
- ~~K~~ like anything else that is collectable
- ~~L~~ but you made me stop and look at it
- ~~M~~ making them more endangered than mammals and birds
- ~~N~~ before the light reveals his crime

0.	1.	2.	3.	4.	5.	6.	7.	8.	9.	10.	11.
N	H	M	K	G	I	A	L	F	B	C	E

2. GUIDED WRITING/ AN E-MAIL

(20 P)

You are spending a semester abroad at Centennial High School in Urbana, Illinois, USA. In the light of the recent school shootings at U.S. schools, the school management has decided to introduce metal detectors and body searches for all who enter the school premises. As a representative of the Student Council, write an e-mail of 150–180 words to the school's headmaster, in which you:

- explain why students oppose this decision;
- suggest alternative ways in which the school can prevent attacks involving firearms.

To...	brown@centennialhigh.com
Subject:	student council opinion

Dear Mr. Brown,

The recent school shootings around the U.S. have left us with an unprecedented situation. However, in the light of the school management's recent proposals of ~~introducing~~ metal detector and body search introduction, (in the name of the Student Council,) ^{feel obliged to} I express strong dissatisfaction with such harsh rules.

To begin with, I feel ^{that body searches are an invasion of my privacy and metal detectors} ~~intruded~~ ^{plundering is awkward} by body searches, which in turn ~~breaks~~ ^{breaks} the trust between ~~us, the~~ students, and the school management. The trust is something we value immensely, therefore such a breach of trust would only lead to more conflicts, and ^{incidents} potentially more shooting occurrences. Moreover, I am also ^{not} ~~sure~~ ^{unassured} about the legality of your proposal, as local laws explicitly prevent body searches unless done by the police with a justified reason. ~~I do not find every day searches security checks justifiable, even if done by policemen or policewomen, which would certainly not be the case for school security checks.~~

Instead, I ^{suggest} ~~propose~~ improving on the field of mental ^{mental health support services} health support, as many shooters often have severe mental problems, but have no one to turn to. ~~I suggest that teachers are well informed about it, as they are often the first person to discover such issues.~~ Furthermore, I also propose better firearm education, which would in turn lead to more responsible ~~fire~~ gun ~~usage~~ use. ^{new paragraph} I firmly

good use of CAUSE & EFFECT approach

believe that ^{my proposals} such would create a better and more positive environment for the students. Therefore I ~~advise~~ urge you to immediately stop the execution of current plans and consider the before-mentioned ~~alternatives~~ ^{voc}

Yours ^{*} faithfully,

-1

John Smith

C	5
S	4
V&R	4-5
G	4